

Voter Resentment and the Strategic Dynamics of Enfranchisement*

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Abstract

Why do parties resist enfranchising new voter groups? Parties that obstruct enfranchisement often accumulate negative sentiment among the affected group, and this resentment manifests as an electoral penalty for the obstructing party if enfranchisement eventually occurs. We formalize the concept of voter resentment, and we develop a dynamic formal model to analyze when and why parties resist enfranchising new voter groups. We identify two main effects of resentment on parties' willingness to enfranchise. Increased voter sensitivity to past disenfranchisement can incentivize incumbent parties to enfranchise sooner ("preemption effect") or to resist enfranchisement entirely ("entrenchment effect"). Party strength, which we define as the share of co-partisans among existing voters, determines which effect dominates. Strong parties entrench against resentment and weak parties preempt. This result is robust to the introduction of uncertainty, exogenous costs or benefits, and an infinite time horizon. We discuss the implications for modern voting rights activists.

Keywords: Enfranchisement, Resentment, Parties, Voting

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While many countries have held competitive elections for centuries, the right to vote in those elections has not always been universal. Countries rarely enfranchise all adults upon initial democratization. Instead, they extend the franchise to select groups at later dates. This was the modal path for women’s suffrage: of the countries where women are enfranchised today, in only 14% were women enfranchised alongside men (Teele, 2018, 2). The path to universal suffrage can also be an iterative process of partial franchise extensions. The United Kingdom, for instance, needed five different reforms to reach full enfranchisement (Freeman and Snidai, 1982). As a result, many franchise extensions have occurred in established electoral settings.

It is not surprising, then, that political parties seek to leverage enfranchisement opportunities for political gain. Parties can pursue new supporters among the unenfranchised (Llavador and Oxoby, 2005), positioning themselves as a champion of that group. Other parties might oppose suffrage, because they anticipate that the new voters would support the opposite party. Such was the case with the United States’s enfranchisement of poor White men, recent immigrants, and Black Americans, wherein political parties established clear positions on suffrage (Keyssar, 2000).

Yet, opposing enfranchisement is not a strategy without risk. We contend that disenfranchised citizens may resent the party that opposes their suffrage, making them disinclined to vote for that party if they were to be enfranchised. Historical accounts and the literature on retrospective voting suggest that resentment may be a byproduct of disenfranchisement, but existing models of franchise extension do not account for such endogenous political preferences. We address this gap in the literature by asking, under what conditions do parties forestall enfranchisement today, risking resentful voters in the future?

To answer this question, we solve a dynamic formal model in which the incumbent chooses to forestall enfranchisement or not, and in so doing generates an observable record of the party’s obstruction. The key parameter in the model is the salience of obstruction to voters. The sensitivity parameter, as we term it, captures how strongly prospective voters condition future support on past obstruction.

Our baseline analysis produces two main findings. First, as potential voters become more sensitive to their disenfranchisement, relatively weak incumbent parties are more likely to enfranchise them. This is because enfranchising today reduces future electoral punishment. We call this the *preemption effect* of resentment. Second, the party’s existing partisan strength can reverse this effect. A party with a strong, loyal base of core voters reacts to sensitivity in the opposite way: Increases in resentment make a strong party less likely to extend the franchise to a resentful new group. Strong parties entrench their opposition to

enfranchisement by relying on current supporters and accumulating resentment among the disenfranchised, and so we call this the *entrenchment effect* of resentment.

The results hold qualitatively under three extensions that better approximate the real world: uncertainty, cost, and an infinite time horizon. We first consider the uncertainty parties face about the partisan allegiance of the individuals they may enfranchise. When we relax the assumption of perfect information and model the precision of parties' information about potential voters, we find that the precision of information about potential voters' latent preferences interacts with partisan strength. Better information encourages a minority party to enfranchise and deters a majority party.

We next allow that franchise extensions may incur costs or benefits that are orthogonal to the party's electoral fortunes. Including this non-electoral parameter reveals two additional results that the simplified model obscures. First, when there is a sufficiently high benefit (cost) to extending the franchise, both parties are willing (unwilling) to enfranchise. Second, when there is a non-zero cost or benefit, party strategy is responsive to the size of the new voter group; when there is a non-electoral benefit (cost), parties are less (more) likely to extend the franchise as the size increases.

Finally, we extend the model to infinite electoral cycles. Solving for a stationary Markov perfect equilibrium, we find that no internal configuration of parameters sustains exclusion forever.

Motivating resentment

The enfranchisement history of Black Americans motivates our model. We connect their experiences with the literature on voting behavior and then argue that existing models of enfranchisement have overlooked voter resentment.

Enfranchisement of Black Americans

When the Civil War ended, the Republican party advocated for the political and civil rights of newly liberated Black Americans. While Democrats opposed Black rights, Republicans across the country “sponsored legislation to grant Blacks their suffrage rights,” and Republican newspapers promoted the cause of Black suffrage (Hanes, 1975, 22-3). Black men rewarded this position by delivering their votes to the Republican, Ulysses S. Grant, in the 1868 presidential election (Coleman, 1933), and over the next decade, Black political leaders ran for office as Republicans and won (Hood, Kidd and Morris, 2012). After Reconstruction ended and as Democrats rescinded Black voting rights, Black opposition to Democrats

persisted. A prominent AME Zion bishop may have reflected a common sentiment when he declared, “The Democratic party has always supported those measures which were opposed to ... the rights of my people. I therefore as a self-respecting black man could not support that party and have always felt it my duty to oppose it.”¹ Allegiance to Republicans after the Civil War is, perhaps, unsurprising. After all, Black men faced a “stark choice”: “Side with those who would extend more rights of citizenship to Black people or with those who would deny them” (Johnson, 2020).

Black Americans again faced such a choice after Democratic president Johnson re-enshrined their suffrage by signing the Voting Rights Act in 1965. Once re-enfranchised, Black Americans remained attuned to the party that had guaranteed their voting rights. Since 1965, Democrats have received an overwhelming majority of Black votes. According to some scholarship, it was the Democratic party’s support for Black political rights that initiated the realignment of Black voters from Republicans to Democrats (Carmines and Stimson, 1989; White and Laird, 2020).²

Voter preferences

Modern efforts to curtail voter participation have also triggered partisan backlash, reflecting voters’ sensitivity to policies affecting the franchise. Since 2002, Republicans in 36 states have passed voter ID laws,³ which politicians and scholars have argued keep Democrats from the polls (Hicks et al., 2015; Fraga and Miller, 2022; Harden and Campos, 2023). Democrats reacted by turning out to vote more for their party, offsetting the small Republican advantage that these laws may otherwise have created (Valentino and Neuner, 2017). Similarly, partisans become angry when learning about other institutional reforms that disadvantage their party—namely, gerrymandering—and this anger translates to higher rates of voting intent (Izatt, 2025). The emotional and mobilizing responses to these recent policies suggest that voters today, as in the 19th and 20th centuries, resent partisan efforts to affect their franchise.

This evidence leads us to conclude that individuals vote retrospectively on parties’ voter policies, which also comports with the literature that voters make retrospective valuations across a range of issues (Healy and Malhotra, 2013). Voters reward politicians for good economic conditions and punish them for bad (Kramer, 1971; Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Kramer, 1983; Woon, 2012); they reward competent responses to natural disaster (Bechtel

¹Bishop Hood, address printed in *The Star of Zion*, May 27, 1897.

²For an alternative perspective suggesting that economic and racial liberalism coalesced decades before the Civil Rights Movement, see Schickler (2016).

³<https://www.ncsl.org/elections-and-campaigns/voter-id>, accessed September 23, 2026.

and Hainmueller, 2011; Gasper and Reeves, 2011); and they punish politicians for war deaths and injuries (Karol and Miguel, 2007). Similar dynamics can exist beyond electoral cycles, with individuals in the minority developing long-lasting animosity toward a government that represses and disenfranchises them (Gibilisco, 2021).

Taken together, the literature suggests that parties’ opposition to enfranchisement can generate resentment and that, once individuals gain the right to vote, such resentment may shape their electoral choices.

Existing models of strategic franchise extensions

In incorporating voter resentment into a model of enfranchisement, we build on and depart from a rich literature in political economy. According to this scholarship, elites extend the franchise as a way to solve (i) external conflict, meaning conflict from below or (ii) internal conflict, meaning among elites (Freeman and Snidai, 1982; Jack and Lagunoff, 2006; Aidt and Franck, 2025).⁴

The literature has identified several types of external conflict that might drive elites to enfranchise: uprisings (Ellis and Fender, 2011; Aidt and Jensen, 2014), non-violent social movements (Banaszak, 1996; McCammon and Campbell, 2001; Tilly, 2004; Teele, 2014), and conscription demands (Janowitz, 1976; Keyssar, 2000; Ticchi and Vindigni, 2008).⁵ Acemoglu and Robinson (2000) canonized the uprising mechanism in their seminal model, in which a unified elite stave off revolution by extending the vote, a credible commitment to future redistribution. This framework provides a powerful explanation for major democratic transitions, but its focus on class conflict between a unified elite and the masses abstracts from the intra-elite competition that often drives institutional change.

Other work highlights internal conflict as a central mechanism, arguing that an economic cleavage among elites can be a catalyst for enfranchisement.⁶ Lizzeri and Persico (2004) claim that when the elites who prefer public goods outnumber those who prefer particularistic transfers, franchise extensions follow. Llavorador and Oxoby (2005) add that, in the presence of such cleavages, political parties can “look to disenfranchised groups for ... political support.” We share Llavorador and Oxoby’s perspective and contend that partisan competition is central to many franchise extensions.

⁴The schema is not mutually exclusive. External conflict, particularly in the form of social movements, can affect how politicians perceive the consequences of franchise extension for intra-elite political competition (Teale, 2018).

⁵See Cox, Dincecco and Onorato (2023) for related work on the effect of war on the emergence of parliamentary governance.

⁶This line of argumentation differs from classic accounts, e.g., Engerman and Sokoloff (2005), that posit enfranchisement is more likely under homogeneous preferences.

Thus, political economists have established that elites extend the franchise as a way to preserve their own power and even to grow their partisan base. While these findings provide a foundation for our study, they overlook that post-enfranchisement political preferences may be endogenous to the timing of enfranchisement itself. We now introduce our baseline model with the novel mechanism of voter resentment.

Model

We analyze a two-period game, $t \in \{1, 2\}$, between two political parties, A and B . In each period t , one party is the incumbent, denoted $I_t \in \{A, B\}$. The incumbent controls the decision on enfranchising new voters.

At the beginning of the game, one party enters with a record of obstruction. That is, the disenfranchised blame one party for their exclusion. We let party A be the incumbent in the first period ($I_1 = A$) and take A to be the party that enters the game carrying a record of obstruction. This captures an empirically relevant case in which the party with an exclusionary history holds office.⁷

The electorate consists of two groups: *core voters*, who are already enfranchised and constitute a measure $1 - \lambda$ of the total, and *potential voters*, who are disenfranchised and constitute a measure λ , where $\lambda \in [0, 1]$. The allegiance of core voters is fixed: a share γ of them supports Party A, and the complementary share $1 - \gamma$ supports Party B. The parameter γ thus quantifies Party A's established partisan strength among core voters. Potential voters, likewise, have partisan leanings. The latent signal $\theta_t \in [0, 1]$ captures their partisan preferences, with a higher θ_t indicating stronger support for Party A among potential voters. At the start of each period t , θ_t is drawn i.i.d. from a uniform distribution $U[0, 1]$ and observed by both parties.

The state variable $E_t \in \{0, 1\}$ tracks the enfranchisement of potential voters, where $E_t = 1$ if they have been enfranchised in any period $k < t$, and $E_t = 0$ otherwise. At the beginning of the game, potential voters are disenfranchised ($E_1 = 0$). If potential voters are not yet enfranchised at the start of period t ($E_t = 0$), the incumbent party I_t decides whether or not to enfranchise them, $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$, where $e_t = 1$ represents enfranchisement and $e_t = 0$ represents non-enfranchisement. Once enfranchised, voters remain enfranchised in all subsequent periods. Formally, $E_{t+1} = \max\{E_t, e_t\}$.

⁷Because resentment is asymmetric (See Assumption 1.), the choice of which party is the period 1 incumbent is not without loss of generality. We select this configuration because it best captures the substantive settings that motivate our analysis.

A core feature of our model is the resentment that potential voters hold toward parties that have impeded their enfranchisement. We model resentment as a pair of state variables $r_t^A, r_t^B \in [0, 1]$, where r_t^i records the hostility of potential voters toward party i at the start of period t . Resentment toward a party accumulates whenever that party, as incumbent, declines to enfranchise:

$$r_{t+1}^i = r_t^i + \beta(1 - r_t^i) \mathbb{I}_{\{I_t=i \wedge E_t=0 \wedge e_t=0\}}, \quad i \in \{A, B\}, \quad (1)$$

where $\beta \in (0, 1]$ governs the extent to which an additional act of obstruction increases resentment. In particular, each period of disenfranchisement moves resentment a fraction β of the remaining distance toward its upper bound of 1. Resentment stops accumulating if enfranchisement occurs, but note that enfranchisement does not erase resentment already accrued.⁸

We specify two assumptions about resentment r_t^A, r_t^B to characterize the historical environment we have in mind. Assumption 1 captures asymmetry in historical responsibility for exclusion. The disenfranchised typically accumulate grievances over generations, and the party controlling the contemporary enfranchisement decision may therefore inherit electoral consequences from its earlier conduct. We normalize resentment toward Party B to zero and allow Party A, the initial incumbent, to enter with positive inherited resentment. This normalization isolates the strategic consequences of an incumbent confronting a group that blames it for past exclusion.⁹

Assumption 1. *At the start of the game,*

$$r_1^A = r_A \in (0, 1), \quad r_1^B = 0.$$

Assumption 2. *Initial resentment toward Party A is sufficiently small:*

$$r_A < \frac{\delta\beta}{2(1+\delta) + \delta\beta}.$$

Assumption 2 limits the magnitude of inherited resentment. This assumption is equivalent to $r_1^A < (r_2^A - r_1^A) \frac{\delta}{2(1+\delta)}$, meaning that inherited resentment is modest relative to the grievance generated by a new act of obstruction. This is natural in settings where the decision at hand constitutes a salient contemporary opportunity to extend the franchise. For

⁸This formulation treats resentment as cumulative. In the infinite-horizon extension, we allow resentment to depreciate toward a party not responsible for continued exclusion.

⁹The assumption is not intended to cover every possible historical configuration. In particular, a newly formed party with no history of exclusion could enter the game with less accumulated resentment than its opponent. We leave such configurations for future work.

instance, potential voters may have some negative assessment of the incumbent, but a fresh and observable decision to continue exclusion can exacerbate resentment.

Voting and Election Outcome

At the end of each period t , an election occurs. The voting behavior of core voters is exogenously fixed, and potential voters participate if and only if they are enfranchised (i.e., $e_t = 1$ or $E_t = 1$).

Should potential voters be enfranchised, the share of them supporting Party A, denoted $s_t^A \in [0, 1]$, is a convex combination of their intrinsic preference – the realized signal $\theta_t \sim U[0, 1]$ – and a resentment-adjusted preference – a function of current resentment levels r_t^A and r_t^B and sensitivity to past disenfranchisement $\alpha \in [0, 1]$. The sensitivity parameter α quantifies the weight potential voters place on historical conduct relative to their intrinsic partisan preference θ_t . If $\alpha = 0$, past disenfranchisement is irrelevant to new voters, and $s_t^A = \theta_t$. Both higher α and higher r_t^A reduce the share supporting Party A, other things being equal. Formally,

$$s_t^A = (1 - \alpha) \theta_t + \alpha (\theta_t (1 - r_t^A) + (1 - \theta_t) r_t^B), \quad (2)$$

$$s_t^B = (1 - \alpha) (1 - \theta_t) + \alpha (\theta_t r_t^A + (1 - \theta_t) (1 - r_t^B)). \quad (3)$$

It is immediate that $s_t^A + s_t^B = 1$ for any $(r_t^A, r_t^B) \in [0, 1]^2$. New voters are fully allocated between parties; there are no abstainers.

Party B does not inherit or accumulate resentment, $r_t^B = 0$, given Assumption 1 and the two-period structure, and so the support function reduces to $s_t^A = \theta_t (1 - \alpha r_t^A)$. On the path where A enfranchises in period 1, $r_t^A = r_A$ in both periods and $s_t^A = \theta_t (1 - \alpha r_A)$, and on the path where A obstructs in period 1 and the group is enfranchised in period 2, $s_2^A = \theta_2 (1 - \alpha r_2^A)$.

The total vote for Party A is $V_t^A = \gamma(1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \lambda s_t^A$, and for Party B is $V_t^B = (1 - \gamma)(1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \lambda s_t^B$. Party A wins the election with probability $p(V_t^A, V_t^B) = V_t^A / (V_t^A + V_t^B)$, and Party B wins with the complementary probability. Since vote shares sum to one, $p(V_t^A, V_t^B) = V_t^A$. When potential voters are not enfranchised, Party A's win probability is γ , and when they are enfranchised, it is $(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda s_t^A$. The winner of the period 1 election becomes the incumbent I_2 for the second period.

Payoffs and Timing

Each party seeks to maximize the expected discounted probability of holding office. Winning the election yields a flow utility $R > 0$, and the future is discounted by $\delta \in (0, 1)$. The total utility for party i is

$$u_i = \sum_{t=1}^2 \delta^{t-1} \cdot R \cdot \mathbb{I}_{I_{t+1}=i}, \quad (4)$$

where the incumbent I_t is determined by the outcome of the election in period t . The timing within period t is as follows.

1. State (I_t, E_t, r_t^A, r_t^B) is known. θ_t is drawn and observed.
2. Incumbent I_t chooses $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$ if $E_t = 0$.
3. Election occurs, and the winner determines I_{t+1} .
4. State variables $E_{t+1}, r_{t+1}^A, r_{t+1}^B$ update according to $E_{t+1} = \max(E_t, e_t)$ and Equation (1).
5. Payoffs for period t are realized. The game ends if $t = 2$.

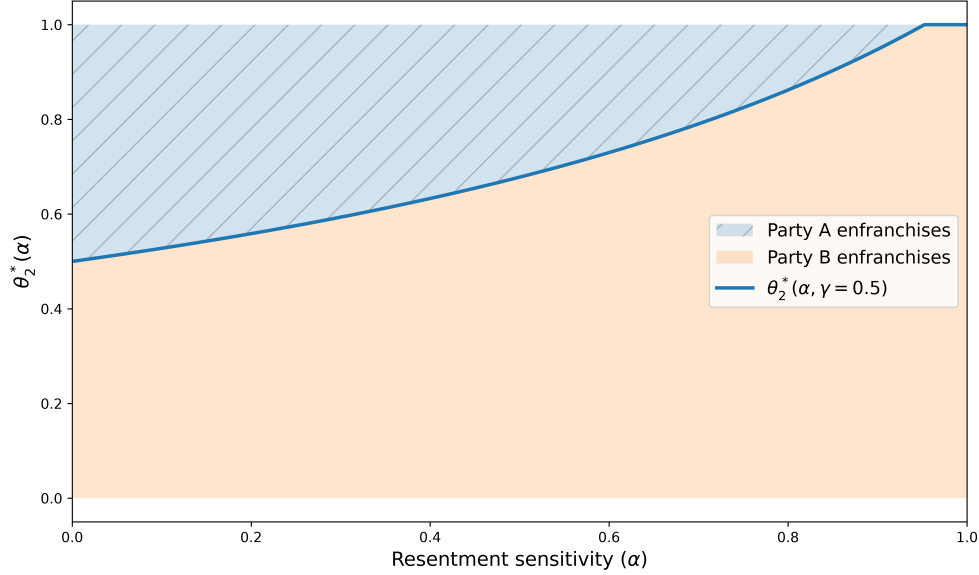
Equilibrium Characterization

The model admits a unique Subgame Perfect Nash Equilibrium. Because the incumbent observes the realization of θ_t before choosing e_t , her problem in each period reduces to comparing the electoral value of an enfranchised group, given current resentment, against the value of the core-voter status quo. The electoral support of an enfranchised group is monotonic in θ_t : A higher realization raises Party A's vote share and lowers Party B's, so enfranchisement becomes more attractive to A, and less attractive to B, as θ_t increases. Given this monotonicity, equilibrium behavior operates according to a shared cutoff, θ_t^* . The parties have a common threshold, because the gain to Party A from enfranchising in period 2 is Party B's loss. This property rests on three features – the constant-sum election, the terminal nature of the period 2 decision, and purely office-motivated parties – which we relax below. Proposition 1 formalizes the strategy in which Party A extends the franchise for high realizations of θ_t and Party B extends it for low realizations.

Proposition 1. *For each period t for Party A, and for period 2 for Party B, there exists a unique threshold which depends on the resentment stock and, for $t = 1$, also on δ , such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\theta_t \geq \theta_t^*$, whereas Party B enfranchises if and only if $\theta_2 < \theta_2^*$.*

Proof. See Appendix A. □

Figure 1: Threshold θ_2^* as function of sensitivity α



Our first result concerns the effect of resentment sensitivity on enfranchisement in the terminal period. If exclusion persists into period 2, only Party A, having been the incumbent in period 1, has accumulated resentment. Greater resentment sensitivity reduces the immediate value of enfranchisement to Party A and increases it for Party B, because potential voters can only harbor resentment toward the period 1 incumbent. Given that it is the final period, Party A and Party B only care about immediate electoral consequences. Therefore, the period 2 threshold strictly increases in resentment sensitivity. Proposition 2 formalizes this result, and Figure 1 illustrates it.

Proposition 2. *The enfranchisement threshold θ_2^* is weakly increasing in α .*

Proof. See Appendix B. □

In period 1, Party A considers not only how enfranchisement affects election prospects today, but also who will control the enfranchisement decision tomorrow. This intertemporal calculus generates our main result: Resentment sensitivity α has a non-monotonic effect on Party A's first-period enfranchisement decision ($e_1 = 1$), and the effect is contingent upon Party A's initial partisan advantage among core voters, γ . Proposition 3 presents this result.

Proposition 3. *There exists a unique partisan strength threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot) \in [0, 1]$ such that the enfranchisement threshold θ_1^* is decreasing in the resentment sensitivity α for $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot)$, and increasing in α for $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot)$.*

Proof. See Appendix C. □

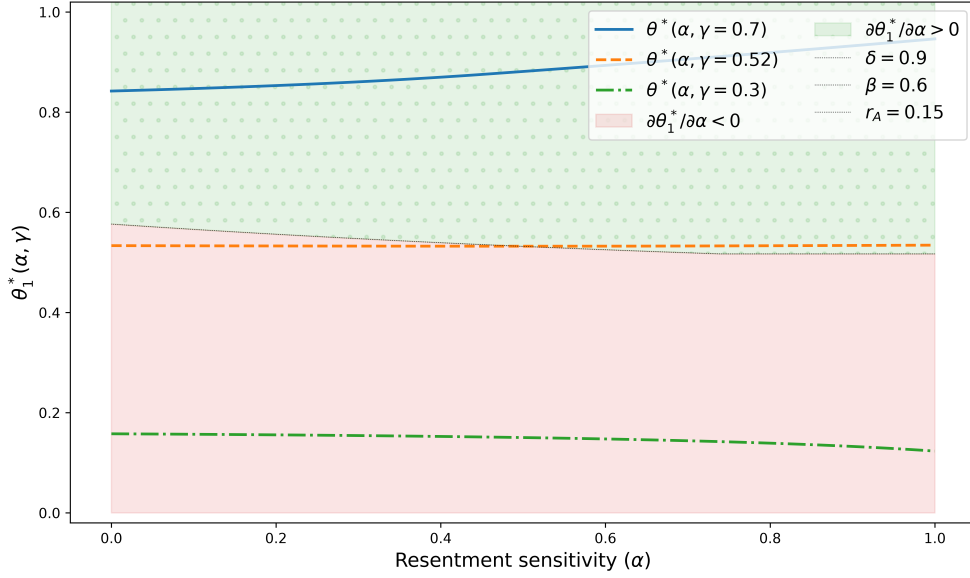
The non-monotonicity derives from two opposing effects of resentment sensitivity α on Party A's intertemporal optimization problem. First, because potential voters enter the game with preexisting resentment r_A , enfranchising them today means incorporating voters whose support is depreciated by α . Consequently, increases in α reduce the share of new voters who would support Party A, disincentivizing Party A from enfranchising today. We refer to this as the *entrenchment effect* of resentment sensitivity.

But there is a second, countervailing force, which we term the *entrenchment effect*. Consider Party A's choice of first-period enfranchisement, $e_1 \in \{0, 1\}$. A decision not to enfranchise in period 1 ($e_1 = 0$) causes potential voters' resentment stock to accumulate from the initial r_A to a higher amount $\bar{r}_A$. Should potential voters then be enfranchised in period 2 — whether by A or by B — a higher sensitivity α exacerbates the electoral penalty from newly accumulated resentment. Thus, increases in α encourage Party A to enfranchise preemptively ($e_1 = 1$) in order to avoid this additional cost.

Party strength determines which effect dominates. When Party A is electorally vulnerable ($\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$), it cannot rely on its core voters to deliver electoral success in period 2. In this case, the preemption effect prevails: Party A needs to secure support from potential voters, and it cannot risk facing a more resentful voting bloc in the future. Conversely, when Party A has a strong partisan base ($\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$), it does not need new voters to achieve a high probability of winning. So, increases in α make enfranchisement even less attractive and entrench Party A on a path of obstruction.

To visualize the preemption and entrenchment effects, Figure 2 plots the first-period enfranchisement threshold as a function of resentment sensitivity, for different levels of party strength. See that for vulnerable parties (the green, dash-dotted curve, for example), increases in sensitivity α are associated with lower thresholds and greater probability of enfranchisement. This trend holds for all parties with $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$; the red region depicts where the preemption effect dominates. Meanwhile, for strong parties (the blue curve, for example), sensitivity raises the threshold. For all parties with $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$ (green region), entrenchment dominates.

Figure 2: Thresholds θ_1^* as functions of sensitivity α



Proposition 4. Let $\gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot)$ be the threshold established in Proposition 3. Then

- i. $\gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot)$ is weakly decreasing in α ;
- ii. $\gamma^*(\alpha, \cdot)$ is decreasing in r_A ; and
- iii. For all $\alpha \in (0, 1)$,

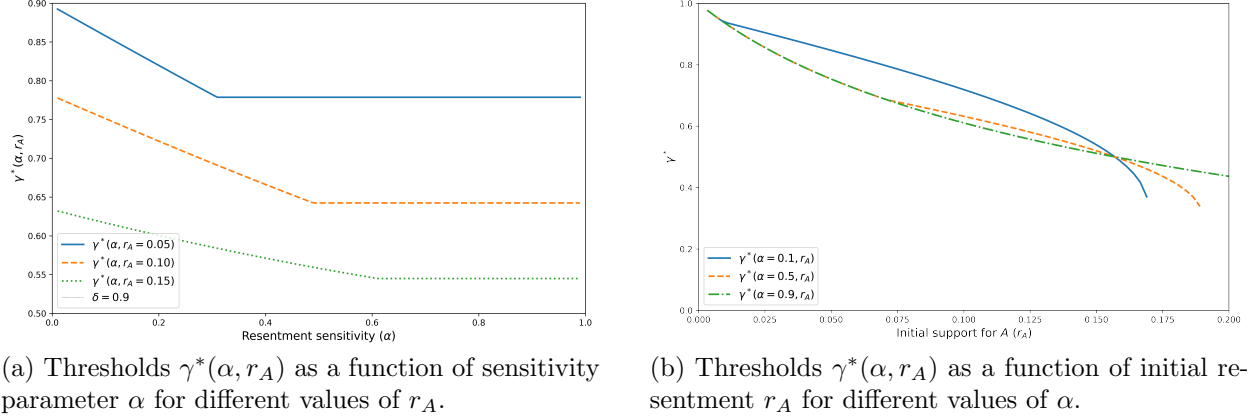
$$1 > \gamma^*(\alpha) \geq 1 - \frac{2(1 + \delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1 - r_A)},$$

and therefore $\lim_{r_A \rightarrow 0} \gamma^*(\alpha) = 1$.

Proof. See Appendix D. □

Figure 3a shows that the cutpoint γ^* is decreasing in α – as sensitivity increases, the entrenchment effect dominates for a wider range of parties. Proposition 4.i formalizes this result, and Proposition 4.ii shows that increases in inherited resentment r_A have the same qualitative effect. Proposition 4.iii clarifies the role of inherited resentment in generating entrenchment – as r_A becomes arbitrarily small, the threshold γ^* converges to one (see Figure 3b). This means that, in the limit in which there is essentially no inherited resentment, only arbitrarily strong parties entrench in response to increasing resentment sensitivity.

Figure 3: Thresholds γ^* as functions of sensitivity and initial resentment



Note: Parties with strength γ above the threshold entrench and parties below the threshold preempt.

Uncertainty over partisanship

When the UK House of Commons extended the suffrage to urban, taxpaying men in 1867, Prime Minister Lord Derby admitted that they were “no doubt ... making a great experiment and ‘taking a leap in the dark.’”¹⁰

Like many politicians who seek to gain more voters through the franchise, Lord Derby was uncertain as to how the newly enfranchised would ultimately vote. In order to deduce potential voters’ allegiance, politicians have relied on group heuristics (Barnes, 2020), economic cleavages (Llavorador and Oxoby, 2005; Ansell and Samuels, 2014), religious identification (Przeworski, 2009), or protest participation (Teele, 2018). Today, politicians might also turn to polling data. Yet, such cues are imperfect predictors of long-run partisanship.¹¹ Uncertainty, thus, appears to be a near ubiquitous features of franchise extensions, but traditional treatments of strategic enfranchisement do not model it. We attempt to fill this gap.

Suppose that parties do not observe θ_t directly. Instead, they observe a common public signal η_t , which we will interpret as the number of respondents who support Party A in a survey of N potential voters. Conditional on true latent support (θ_t), this signal is drawn from a binomial distribution $\eta_t | \theta_t \sim \text{Binomial}(N, \theta_t)$. Given the uniform prior $\theta_t \sim U[0, 1]$,

¹⁰Edward Stanley, 14th Earl of Derby. 1867. Speech in the House of Lords, August 6, 1867. *Hansard Parliamentary Debates*, volume 189. <https://hansard.parliament.uk/Lords/1867-08-06/debates/66b289d4-444f-4c72-9900-4a662b500b12/ThirdReading>, accessed September 15, 2026.

¹¹For the limitations of the “woman voter” heuristic in the U.S., see McConaughy (2013); Wolbrecht and Corder (2020).

the posterior distribution following realization η_t is

$$\theta_t | \eta_t \sim \text{Beta}(\eta_t + 1, N - \eta_t + 1). \quad (5)$$

Let $\hat{\theta}_t(\eta_t) := \mathbb{E}[\theta_t | \eta_t] = \frac{\eta_t + 1}{N + 2}$ denote the posterior mean.¹² Because expected electoral payoffs are linear in θ_t , the posterior mean is a sufficient statistic for the enfranchisement decision. Parties evaluate the electoral consequences of enfranchisement exactly as in the baseline model, replacing the realized θ_t with $\hat{\theta}_t(\eta_t)$ (see Proposition 5). The complete-information benchmark is obtained in the limit as the survey becomes arbitrarily precise.

Proposition 5. *For each period t and each incumbent $I_t \in \{A, B\}$, there exists a unique threshold $\hat{\theta}_t^*$, such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_t \geq \hat{\theta}_t^*$, and Party B enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_t < \hat{\theta}_t^*$.*

Proof. See Appendix S2. □

Uncertainty maintains the central strategic trade-off of the baseline model, with the preemption effect dominating for weaker parties and entrenchment dominating for stronger parties. Survey precision affects the continuation value of delaying enfranchisement and therefore changes the location of the partisan-strength threshold from $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ to $\gamma^*(\alpha, N)$, but not the qualitative single-crossing structure (see Proposition 6.i).

Proposition 6. *For every survey size N ,*

- i. there exists a unique partisan-strength threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha, N) \in (0, 1)$ such that the first-period posterior-mean threshold $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ is decreasing in resentment sensitivity α for $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$, and increasing in α for $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$; and*
- ii. party strength moderates effect of higher precision as follows*

$$\hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N + 1) \begin{cases} \leq \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma < \frac{1}{2}, \\ = \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma = \frac{1}{2}, \\ \geq \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma > \frac{1}{2}. \end{cases} \quad (6)$$

Proof. See Appendix S3. □

¹²Note that because the posterior mean takes values on a discrete grid, the ex ante probability of first-period enfranchisement does not coincide exactly with the continuous approximation $1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*$. Appendix S1 shows that the discrepancy is uniformly small and vanishes as survey precision increases.

In addition to preserving the baseline result, introducing uncertainty adds a role for information precision. Note that the incumbent’s assessment of the current electorate is already summarized by the posterior mean ($\hat{\theta}_1$), and so for any given $\hat{\theta}_1$, better information does not affect the period 1 payoff from enfranchisement. But, if the incumbent obstructs in period 1, enfranchisement decisions in period 2 would benefit from more precise information. In order to reap these informational benefits, the incumbent must be able to win the election in period 1 without enfranchising potential voters. Therefore, parties with majority core support, $\gamma \geq \frac{1}{2}$, become less willing to enfranchise in period 1 as information precision increases, and inversely for minority parties, $\gamma < \frac{1}{2}$ (see Proposition 6.ii.)

Remark 1. Under Assumption 2, the partisan strength threshold satisfies $\gamma^* \geq 1/2$.

Proof. See Appendix S4 □

Remark 1 establishes that γ^* , the cutpoint for the resentment comparative statics, always exceeds $\frac{1}{2}$. This ordering of thresholds allows us to identify three substantively different regions, which we summarize in Table 1. For minority parties ($\gamma < \frac{1}{2}$) greater information and greater resentment sensitivity promote enfranchisement, because the parties are unlikely to be in office in period 2, when they could benefit from better information, and they cannot withstand additional costs of resentment. Conversely, strong parties ($\gamma \geq \gamma^*$) respond to both information and resentment sensitivity by becoming less likely to enfranchise. But for intermediate parties ($\gamma \in [\frac{1}{2}, \gamma^*)$), information and resentment sensitivity have opposite effects. The party is sufficiently strong such that it expects to remain in office and benefit from better information in period 2, and so the prospect of better information incentivizes the party not to enfranchise in period 1. However, the party is not so strong that it is invulnerable to the electoral consequences of additional resentment, and greater sensitivity to resentment encourages the party to enfranchise immediately.

Table 1: Effects of information and resentment sensitivity on enfranchisement

Partisan strength	Information	Resentment sensitivity
Strong ($\gamma > \gamma^*$)	—	—
Majority ($\frac{1}{2} < \gamma < \gamma^*$)	—	+
Minority ($\gamma < \frac{1}{2}$)	+	+

Notes: + implies an increase in the corresponding parameter raises the probability of first-period enfranchisement; — implies that it lowers it.

Non-electoral cost and benefits

A bronze statue on Market Street in Knoxville, Tennessee memorializes state legislator Harry T. Burns and his mother. The subject of the statue would be little known, but for being the pivotal vote in the final state required to ratify the 19th amendment. Of course, Burns did not necessarily vote for the bill because he yearned for bronze immortality. No, he did it for another non-electoral reason: His mother told him to. Indeed, when Burns was wavering on the issue of suffrage, it was not the prospect of votes, but a letter from his mother, that pushed him to vote yes (Weiss, 2018).

As Burns saw, there can be non-electoral benefits, as well as costs, to extending the franchise. Party leaders can cement a legacy (perhaps, in bronze) or uphold a personal sense of fairness (or familial obligation). Alternatively, parties may have to navigate a difficult legislative process in order to pass franchise reform. To capture the non-electoral costs and benefits to franchise extension, we now allow that enfranchisement incurs a one-time net cost $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Positive values of c represent a cost of enfranchisement, while negative values represent a benefit. Normalizing the value of office to one, party i 's payoff becomes

$$u_i = \sum_{t=1}^2 \delta^{t-1} \left(\mathbb{1}_{\{I_{t+1}=i\}} - c \mathbb{1}_{\{I_t=i \wedge E_t=0 \wedge e_t=1\}} \right).$$

Proposition 7. *In period 2,*

i. the parties' enfranchisement thresholds are

$$\theta_{2,A}^*(c) = \max\{0, \min\{1, \frac{\gamma + c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}\}\} \quad \text{and} \quad \theta_{2,B}^*(c) = \max\{0, \min\{1, \frac{\gamma - c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}\}\};$$

and

ii. the thresholds satisfy

$$\frac{\partial \theta_{t,A}^*(c)}{\partial c} \geq 0, \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial \theta_{2,B}^*(c)}{\partial c} \leq 0,$$

for $t \in \{1, 2\}$.

Proof. See Appendix S6. □

As Proposition 7.i highlights, introducing net cost preserves the cutoff structure of the equilibrium but replaces the common enfranchisement threshold with party-specific cutoffs. Figure 4 plots these period 2 thresholds as functions of the net cost c . A nonzero net

cost generates a wedge between the parties' enfranchisement cutoffs, which means there are regions in the parameter space where neither party extends the franchise (white area) and where both parties enfranchise (overlapping area). See that at $c = 0$, the thresholds $\theta_{2,A}^*$ and $\theta_{2,B}^*$ coincide, recovering the baseline result.

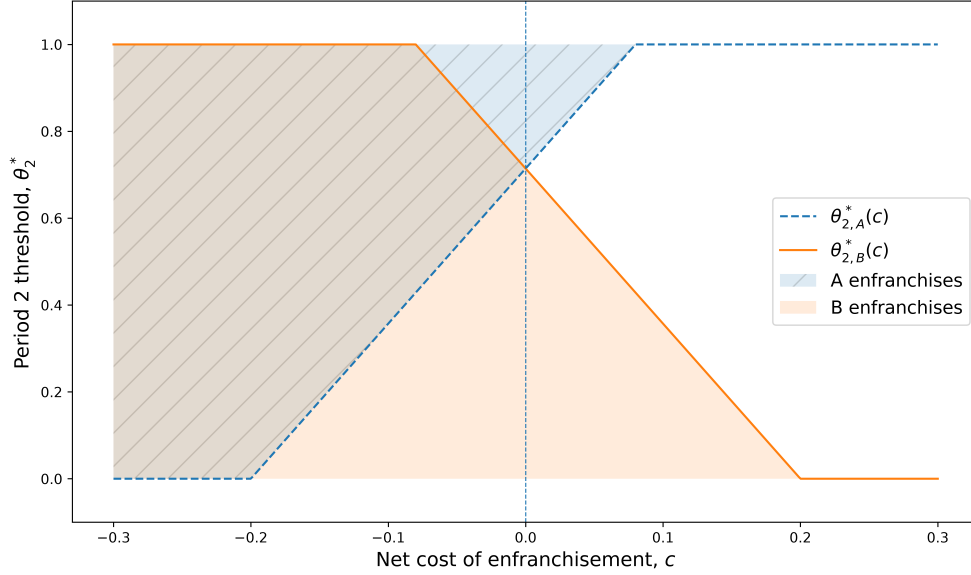


Figure 4: Second-period enfranchisement thresholds for Party A and Party B as a function of net cost c .

Proposition 8. *The magnitude of the effect of cost on first-period enfranchisement depends on Party A's strength as follows*

$$\frac{\partial^2 \Pr[e_1 = 1 \mid c]}{\partial c \partial \gamma} \begin{cases} \geq 0, & \gamma < \gamma^c(\alpha), \\ = 0, & \gamma = \gamma^c(\alpha), \\ \leq 0, & \gamma > \gamma^c(\alpha), \end{cases}$$

where $\gamma^c(\alpha) \equiv \frac{1-\alpha r_2^A}{2} \leq 1/2$.

Proof. See Appendix S7. □

Proposition 7.ii establishes that enfranchisement becomes less likely as cost increases. The magnitude of this negative effect, however, varies with partisan strength. See Proposition 8. In particular, for $\gamma < \gamma^c(\alpha)$, the cost effect becomes smaller as γ increases, while for $\gamma > \gamma^c(\alpha)$ it becomes larger. Thus, parties at the intermediate level (around $\gamma^c(\alpha)$) are most insensitive to the costs or benefits of enfranchisement. Figure 5 depicts this insensitivity.

The intuition lies in the electoral position of intermediate parties relative to weak or strong parties. Intermediate parties are competitive, but in order to ensure victory, they need to attract new supporters. The partisan preferences of potential voters, therefore, are more important to the party than are marginal changes in the direct cost or benefit of franchise extension. In contrast, very weak or very strong parties are relatively more insensitive to marginal changes in potential voters' support, because they are so secured in their respective positions of extending or opposing the franchise.

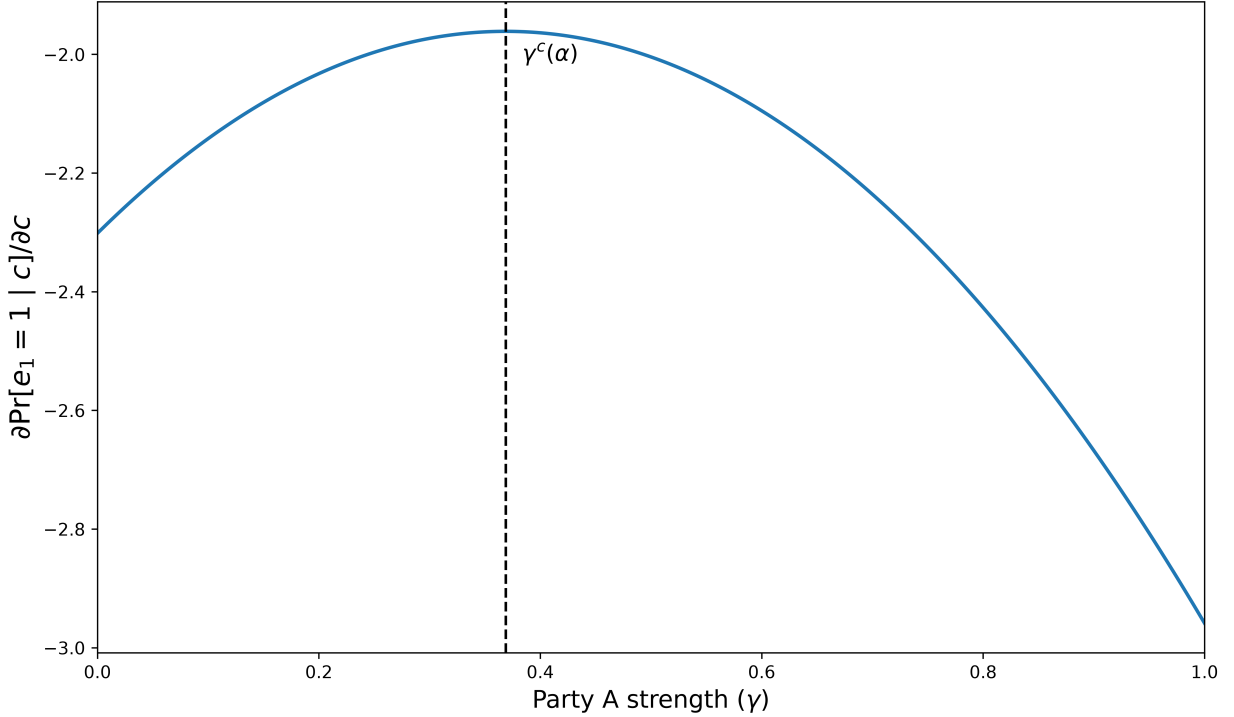


Figure 5: Effect of a higher cost on first-period enfranchisement as a function of Party A's strength.

Proposition 9. *Parties' enfranchisement thresholds satisfy*

$$\frac{\partial \theta_{t,A}^*(c, \lambda)}{\partial \lambda} \begin{cases} \leq 0, & c > 0, \\ = 0, & c = 0, \\ \geq 0, & c < 0, \end{cases} \quad and \quad \frac{\partial \theta_{2,B}^*(c, \lambda)}{\partial \lambda} \begin{cases} \geq 0, & c > 0, \\ = 0, & c = 0, \\ \leq 0, & c < 0, \end{cases}$$

for $t \in \{1, 2\}$.

Proof. See Appendix S8. □

Observe also that the size of the potential electorate (λ) becomes relevant once enfranchisement carries a net cost. In the baseline model, the size λ only scales the electoral con-

sequences of enfranchisement and, thus, does not affect parties' enfranchisement decisions. Once enfranchisement carries a net cost, however, a larger potential electorate reduces the importance of that cost relative to the electoral stakes. So, when there is a cost to enfranchisement, parties' willingness to enfranchise increases in the size of the potential electorate, and when there is a benefit, parties' willingness decreases in λ . Proposition 9 formalizes this result, and Figure 6 depicts the dual effects of λ on the second-period threshold.

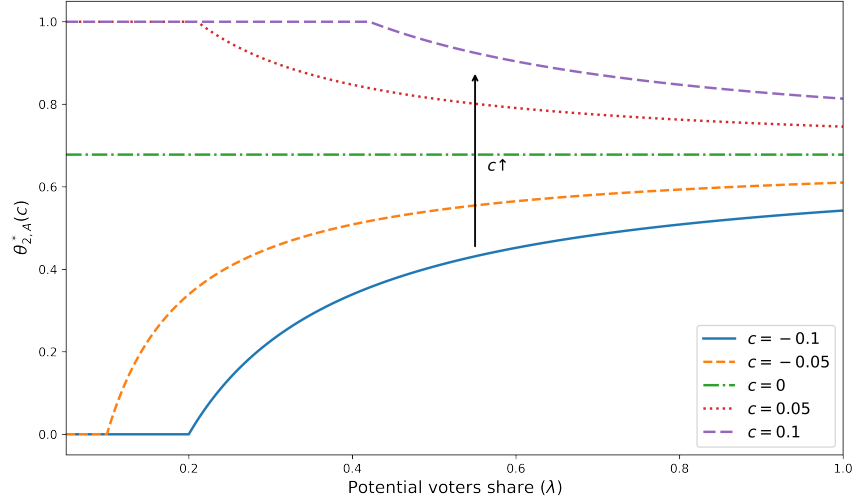


Figure 6: The threshold $\theta_{2,A}^*$ as a function of λ for different values of c .

Infinite electoral cycles

Japan held its first parliamentary election in 1890, with men who paid at least 15 yen in federal taxes able to participate. The legislature began lowering this requirement in 1900, and by 1919, the Kenseikai, the major opposition party, announced its support for full male suffrage. The governing party, Seiyūkai, continued to resist calls to expand the suffrage, but when it earned a minority of seats in the 1924 election, it was forced to concede the issue (Griffin, 1972). Over the next electoral cycles, the Seiyūkai struggled to regain a majority (Colegrove, 1928).

A 35-year fight for the franchise, as Japanese men experienced, is not abnormally long. Parties often leave office and later return to face the consequences of their earlier conduct. Continued exclusion can therefore shape future electoral incentives even after turnover. To capture this dynamic, we now allow parties to compete indefinitely.¹³ This extension allows

¹³We abstract from term limits and interpret the political actors as parties rather than individual officeholders.

us to study whether exclusion can persist, and if partisan strength determines the effect of resentment, over an infinite horizon.

Time is infinite, $t = 1, 2, 3, \dots$. The payoff-relevant state at the beginning of period t is (I_t, E_t, r_t^A, r_t^B) , where $I_t \in \{A, B\}$ denotes the incumbent, $E_t \in \{0, 1\}$ records whether potential voters have been enfranchised, and (r_t^A, r_t^B) denote resentment toward the two parties. Conditional on this state, the partisan leaning of potential voters, θ_t , is drawn independently $\theta_t \sim U[0, 1]$ and publicly observed before the incumbent chooses whether to enfranchise.

As before, $E_{t+1} = \max\{E_t, e_t\}$, so enfranchisement is absorbing. As long as potential voters are excluded, resentment changes according to

$$r_{t+1}^i = (1 - \beta)r_t^i + \beta \cdot \mathbb{1}\{I_t = i, e_t = 0\}, \quad i \in A, B.$$

For the first two periods, the process of resentment accumulation is identical to that in the baseline model. Beyond period 2, we allow resentment to decay against non-incumbent parties. Specifically, obstruction by party i increases resentment toward party i and depreciates resentment toward party $-i$. Once enfranchisement occurs, resentment does not change. We focus on stationary Markov perfect equilibria, and we find that the equilibrium cutoff structure survives under an infinite horizon. Party A enfranchises when potential voters are sufficiently favorable to it, while Party B does so when they are sufficiently unfavorable to A. Proposition 10 formalizes this result.

Proposition 10. *There exists a unique stationary Markov perfect equilibrium. For every resentment state (r_A, r_B) , there exist unique thresholds $\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$, and $\theta_{B,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$ such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\theta_t \geq \theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$, while Party B enfranchises if and only if $\theta_t < \theta_{B,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$.*

Proof. See Appendix S9. □

Proposition 11. *Let τ denote the first period in which voters are enfranchised, and suppose $\gamma \in (0, 1)$. Then, in the unique Markov perfect equilibrium,*

1. *enfranchisement occurs almost surely, $\Pr[\tau < \infty] = 1$; and*
2. *the expected duration of exclusion is finite, $E[\tau] \leq 1 + \frac{1}{\min\{\gamma, 1-\gamma\}}$.*

Proof. See Appendix S10. □

Proposition 11 establishes that no configuration of partisan strength, initial resentment, and resentment sensitivity sustains exclusion forever, provided both parties have some chance

of holding office. Resentment cannot support permanent exclusion, because its electoral consequences are asymmetric across parties. When resentment accumulates against the party responsible for obstruction, enfranchisement becomes less attractive to that party and more attractive to its opponent.

Proposition 12. *Suppose Party A is the incumbent at resentment state $(r_A, 0)$ and let $\min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\} > \alpha_H > \alpha_L$. Then, there exists $K(\gamma) < \infty$ and $\underline{\delta}(\gamma) > 0$ such that for every $k > K(\gamma)$ and $\delta < \underline{\delta}(\gamma)$,*

$$\mathbb{E} \left(\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_{t+k}^A, r_{t+k}^B; \alpha_H, \gamma) - \theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_{t+k}^A, r_{t+k}^B; \alpha_L, \gamma) \right) \begin{cases} < 0, & \gamma < \frac{1}{2}, \\ > 0, & \gamma > \frac{1}{2}. \end{cases}$$

Proof. See Appendix S11. □

Responsibility for continued exclusion becomes endogenous to parties' electoral strength under an infinite horizon and decaying resentment. As exclusion persists, the party that holds office most is also the one to generate more resentment. Proposition 12 shows how this endogenous accumulation of resentment shapes the effect of voter sensitivity on incentives to enfranchise. When Party A is electorally weak, it is less likely to have governed during exclusion, and so it faces less resentment than Party B. Greater sensitivity to resentment, then, improves A's relative standing among potential voters, making enfranchisement more attractive to Party A. When Party A is strong, the opposite holds. Party A bears more resentment, and so greater sensitivity makes enfranchisement less attractive. This result echoes the baseline model – weaker parties are more likely to enfranchise as resentment sensitivity increases, while stronger parties are less likely.

Discussion

Political and partisan preferences are not limited to current voters: Preferences of potential voters also shape politicians' behaviors. Scholarship on representation and franchise expansion should, therefore, treat the disenfranchised as forward-looking political actors, whose partisan attachments can either constrain or enable incumbents. We contribute to this effort by arguing that voter resentment toward parties' past enfranchisement decisions is a crucial, endogenous feature of the politics of enfranchisement. We find that, when confronting increased sensitivity to resentment, weak parties become more willing to enfranchise and strong parties become less willing. The result holds when we introduce uncertainty, exoge-

nous costs, and an infinite time horizon. We conclude by discussing some implications of our results and opportunities for future work.

Scholars have established that competition is associated with more enfranchisement (e.g., Teele (2018); Llavador and Oxoby (2005); Collier (1999)). Our resentment mechanism and result offers an explanation for this empirical regularity. Parties in a competitive environment cannot afford to accumulate resentment among the currently excluded voters, because those citizens could become pivotal once enfranchised. In contrast, dominant parties anticipate continued electoral success and do not expect they will have to internalize future backlash from excluded voters.

These dynamics are pertinent to modern voting rights activists. A common feature of voting rights activism is elevating the salience of enfranchisement over other compelling issues (Morgan-Collins, 2025); this corresponds with an increase in sensitivity in our model. With that in mind, activists may want to consider the competitive environment in which they mobilize. Activism that raises the salience of the franchise is most effective where competition is already tight and the incumbent cannot afford to forgo support from newly enfranchised voters. Where the incumbent party is dominant, however, heightened resentment can instead postpone inclusion.

Not only might these movements backfire against strong incumbents, but they can also move a middling party from preemption to entrenchment. Our model captures this dynamic in the downward-sloping threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$. As disenfranchisement becomes more salient, the set of parties that follow an entrenchment strategy expands. In such cases, suffrage advocates may need to pair rights-based mobilization with efforts that increase electoral competitiveness, like coalition-building, registering existing constituents, and supporting viable challengers, so that enfranchisement becomes strategically attractive for the incumbent.

Like any model, ours has limitations. We identify two with substantive bearing.

Throughout, we specify that enfranchisement is absorbing. Yet, as the case of Black Americans illustrates, elites can both extend and retract the franchise. This is not only the case historically, but today as well, as politicians and courts disenfranchise voters with criminal records.¹⁴ Modern voting-rights struggles have also illustrated that not just the disenfranchised, but current voters, have preferences over whom is incorporated in the franchise (Alarian and Zonszein, 2025). While in this paper we isolated non-voters' preferences on enfranchisement policy, we anticipate that current voters' resentment over who is or is

¹⁴A recent case in North Carolina embodied these dynamics, as the NC Supreme Court reinstated voter restrictions for convicted felons. <https://www.ncsbe.gov/news/press-releases/2021/09/13/statement-nc-supreme-court-order-community-success-initiative-v-moore-case>, accessed September 22, 2026.

not enfranchised will also affect politicians' willingness to extend the franchise. We hope to specify this in future work.

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Appendix

A Proposition 1

We solve the game by backward induction. Because the electorate is fully allocated between the two parties, the election is constant-sum:

$$V_t^A + V_t^B = 1.$$

A party's probability of winning the election exactly equals its expected vote share. Thus, maximizing the expected discounted probability of holding office is strictly equivalent to maximizing expected vote share.

In the terminal period $t = 2$ if the potential voters are not yet enfranchised ($E_2 = 0$), the incumbent $I_2 \in \{A, B\}$ must choose $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$. If Party A is the incumbent, it chooses $e_2 = 1$ if and only if the resulting vote share weakly exceeds the status quo

$$\begin{aligned} V_2^A(e_2 = 1) \geq V_2^A(e_2 = 0) &\Leftrightarrow (1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \geq \gamma \\ \Leftrightarrow \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \geq \lambda\gamma &\Leftrightarrow \theta_2 \geq \tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma) \equiv \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}. \end{aligned}$$

Because θ_2 must be drawn from $U[0, 1]$, the true equilibrium threshold θ_2^* is bounded on the interval $[0, 1]$. Formally, $\theta_2^* = \min \left\{ 1, \tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma) \right\}$. Party A enfranchises if and only if $\theta_2 \geq \theta_2^*$. If Party B is the incumbent, it seeks to maximize V_2^B , which is strictly equivalent to minimizing V_2^A . Therefore, Party B enfranchises if and only if $V_2^A(1) < V_2^A(0)$, or, equivalently, $\theta_2 < \theta_2^*$.

We now proceed to $t = 1$. Let $W_i(e_1)$ denote the expected total discounted utility for party $i \in \{A, B\}$. For Party A:

$$W_A(e_1) = V_1^A(e_1) + \delta \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid e_1]$$

Party A chooses $e_1 = 1$ if and only if $W_A(1) - W_A(0) \geq 0$. Substituting the period 1 vote shares we get:

$$\lambda\theta_1(1 - \alpha r_A) - \lambda\gamma + \delta(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]) \geq 0$$

Because $\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]$ depends on whether the period 2 threshold θ_2^* is interior or at a corner, the unconstrained period 1 threshold, $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma)$, takes a piecewise form.

Suppose $\gamma < 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$, $\theta_2^* \in (0, 1)$. Evaluating the expected continuation value under $E_2 = 0$ we get

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] &= \gamma\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = A] + (1 - \gamma)\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = B] \\ &= \gamma + \lambda(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A) \left(\gamma \int \tilde{\theta}_2^1(\theta_2 - \tilde{\theta}_2) d\theta_2 + (1 - \gamma) \int_0^{\tilde{\theta}_2} (\theta_2 - \tilde{\theta}_2) d\theta_2 \right)\end{aligned}$$

Integrating and substituting $\tilde{\theta}_2 = \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A}$:

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] = \gamma + \frac{\lambda\gamma}{2(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)} ((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)^2 - 2\gamma(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A) - \gamma(1 - 2\gamma)).$$

Substituting both expected values back into the period 1 indifference condition and solving for θ_1 isolates $\tilde{\theta}_1$

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta\gamma((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)^2 + 2(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A) + \gamma(2\gamma - 1))}{2(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)(1 - \alpha r_A)}.$$

Suppose next $\gamma \geq 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$, $\theta_2^* = 1$. Party A never enfranchises in period 2, and Party B always does.

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = A] = \gamma, \quad \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = B] = (1 - \lambda)\gamma + \frac{\lambda}{2}(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)$$

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] = \gamma - \lambda\gamma(1 - \gamma) + \frac{\lambda}{2}(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)$$

Substituting this back into the indifference condition we get

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2)}{2(1 - \alpha r_A)}.$$

Because the realized signal θ_1 is constrained to the unit interval, the true equilibrium threshold is bounded

$$\theta_1^*(\alpha, \gamma) = \max \left\{ 0, \min \left\{ 1, \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) \right\} \right\}. \quad (7)$$

When $\tilde{\theta}_1 \leq 0$, the future continuation value dominates and Party A always enfranchises; if $\tilde{\theta}_1 \geq 1$, the risk of oppositional voting dominates and Party A never enfranchises. In the interior where $\tilde{\theta}_1 \in (0, 1)$, Party A enfranchises conditionally if and only if $\theta_1 \geq \theta_1^*$.

Finally, because the game is zero-sum in electoral probabilities, Party B's expected total utility is inverse: $W_B(e_1) = 1 + \delta - W_A(e_1)$. If Party B were the incumbent, it would choose $e_1 = 1$ if and only if $W_B(1) - W_B(0) > 0$. This simplifies directly to $W_A(1) - W_A(0) < 0$, the

exact logical negation of Party A's condition. Therefore, Party B enfranchises if and only if $\theta_1 < \theta_1^*(\alpha, \gamma)$.

B Proposition 2

Recall from Appendix A that the unconstrained second period enfranchisement threshold is $\tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma) = \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}$. Note that it is strictly increasing α :

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma)}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\partial}{\partial \alpha} \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A} = \frac{\gamma r_2^A}{(1 - \alpha r_2^A)^2} > 0.$$

The equilibrium threshold θ_2^* is the truncation of this unconstrained cutoff to the feasible state space. It is, thus, weakly increasing in α .

C Proposition 3

We analyze the unconstrained threshold $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma)$ derived in Appendix A. Because the equilibrium threshold is bounded as $\theta_1^* = \max\{0, \min\{1, \tilde{\theta}_1\}\}$, strict monotonicity of $\tilde{\theta}_1$ transfers directly to θ_1^* wherever $\tilde{\theta}_1 \in (0, 1)$, holding weakly at the boundaries. We restrict attention to $\gamma \in (0, 1]$ since $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, 0) \equiv -\frac{\delta}{2}$. We differentiate $\tilde{\theta}_1$ wrt α across two cases.

Suppose $\gamma \geq 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A$. Then

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{1}{1 - \alpha r_A} \left(\gamma + \frac{\delta}{2} ((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2) \right).$$

Derivate wrt α

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_1}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{N(\gamma)}{(1 - \alpha r_A)^2},$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} N(\gamma) &\equiv (1 - \alpha r_A) \left(-\frac{\delta \bar{r}_A}{2} (1 - \gamma) \right) + r_A \left(\gamma + \frac{\delta}{2} ((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2) \right) \\ &= \delta r_A \gamma^2 + r_A \gamma - \frac{\delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)}{2} (1 - \gamma). \end{aligned} \tag{8}$$

Suppose, next, $\gamma < 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A$. Then

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta \gamma ((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2 + 2(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \gamma(2\gamma - 1))}{2(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)(1 - \alpha r_A)}$$

and

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_1}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\gamma \cdot P(\gamma; \alpha)}{2(1 - \alpha r_A)^2(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2},$$

where

$$P(\gamma; \alpha) \equiv 2\delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A))\gamma^2 - \delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A) + 2r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2)\gamma + (1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2(2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)). \quad (9)$$

Because $\bar{r}_A - r_A = \beta(1 - r_A) > 0$, $N(\gamma)$ is strictly convex with $N(0) = -\frac{\delta}{2}\beta(1 - r_A) < 0$ and $N(1) = (1 + \delta)r_A > 0$. Thus, $N(\gamma)$ crosses zero exactly once, and has a unique root $\gamma_N \in (0, 1)$ such that $N(\gamma) < 0$ for $\gamma < \gamma_N$ and $N(\gamma) > 0$ for $\gamma > \gamma_N$. Unique positive root $\gamma_N \in (0, 1)$ of this quadratic formula is

$$\gamma_N = \frac{-\left(r_A + \frac{\delta\beta(1-r_A)}{2}\right) + \sqrt{\left(r_A + \frac{\delta\beta(1-r_A)}{2}\right)^2 + 2\delta^2 r_A \beta(1 - r_A)}}{2\delta r_A}.$$

Similarly, $P(\gamma; \alpha)$ is strictly convex in γ . Under the parametric condition $r_A < \frac{\delta\beta}{2(1+\delta)+\delta\beta}$, it strictly follows that $2(1 + \delta)r_A < \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)$, and $P(0; \alpha) < 0$. Because $P(1; \alpha) > 0$, $P(\gamma; \alpha)$ has a unique positive root $\gamma_I(\alpha)$ such that $P < 0$ on $(0, \gamma_I)$ and $P > 0$ on (γ_I, ∞) . Denote

$$a_P \equiv 2\delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A)); \quad b_P \equiv \delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A) + 2r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2);$$

$$c_P \equiv (1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2(2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)),$$

then

$$\gamma_I(\alpha) = \frac{-b_P + \sqrt{b_P^2 - 4a_P c_P}}{2a_P}.$$

We formally define $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ as

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) = \begin{cases} \gamma_I(\alpha) & \text{if } \gamma_I(\alpha) < 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A, \\ \gamma_N & \text{if } \gamma_I(\alpha) \geq 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A. \end{cases}$$

D Proposition 4

i. The threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ is defined in Appendix C as $\min(\gamma_I(\alpha), \gamma_N)$. Because γ_N is the root of $N(\gamma) = 0$ and is independent of α , $\frac{\partial \gamma_N}{\partial \alpha} = 0$. We must show $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} < 0$ in the interior regime where $\gamma^* = \gamma_I$.

The threshold γ_I is the unique positive root of $P(\gamma; \alpha) = 0$. By the Implicit Function Theorem, $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} = -\frac{\partial P / \partial \alpha}{\partial P / \partial \gamma}$. Because $P(0; \alpha) < 0$ and $P(\gamma_I; \alpha) = 0$, the function crosses zero from below, implying $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \gamma} > 0$ at γ_I . Differentiate P with respect to $\bar{\sigma}$

$$\frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} = 2\delta r_A \gamma (2\gamma - 1 - 2\bar{\sigma}) + 2\bar{\sigma} (2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta\beta(1 - r_A)).$$

Under Condition (S), the bracketed constant is strictly negative. In the interior regime, $\gamma_I < \bar{\sigma}$, ensuring $2\gamma_I - 1 - 2\bar{\sigma} < -1 < 0$. Therefore, both terms are strictly negative, thus, $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} < 0$. Since $\bar{\sigma} = 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$, we have $\frac{\partial \bar{\sigma}}{\partial \alpha} = -\bar{r}_A < 0$. Therefore, $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} \frac{\partial \bar{\sigma}}{\partial \alpha} > 0$. Consequently, $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} < 0$ and, thus, $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial \alpha} \leq 0$.

ii. The threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ is either γ_N or γ_I . Both roots share identical dependence on r_A , thus, evaluating root γ_N is sufficient to establish the comparative static: same implicit differentiation applies to $P(\gamma; \alpha)$.

Differentiate N with respect to r_A

$$\frac{\partial N}{\partial r_A} = \delta\gamma^2 + \gamma + \frac{\delta\beta}{2}(1 - \gamma) > 0$$

Because $N(\gamma)$ is convex and crosses zero from below, $\frac{\partial N}{\partial \gamma} > 0$ at γ_N . Thus, $\frac{\partial \gamma_N}{\partial r_A} = -\frac{\partial N / \partial r_A}{\partial N / \partial \gamma} < 0$. An increase in baseline resentment r_A strictly increases the period 2 electoral penalty of current obstruction, amplifying the entrenchment effect. Thus, $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial r_A} < 0$.

iii. By part i, $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial \alpha} \leq 0$. Thus $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ is minimal at $\alpha = 1$. At this boundary $\gamma^*(1) = \gamma_N$ and, thus, γ_N serves as the global lower bound for $\gamma^*(\alpha)$.

Because $N(\gamma)$ is strictly convex with $N(0) < 0$ and $N(1) > 0$, and $\gamma^2 < \gamma$, $N(\gamma)$ is strictly bounded by

$$N(\gamma) < r_A(1 + \delta)\gamma - \frac{\delta\beta(1 - r_A)}{2}(1 - \gamma).$$

The root of this upper bound bounds γ_N , thus

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) \geq \gamma_N > 1 - \frac{2(1 + \delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1 - r_A)}.$$

Note that $2(1 + \delta)r_A > 2r_A$, thus

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) \geq 1 - \frac{2(1 + \delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1 - r_A)}.$$

Note that RHS converges to 1 as r_A converges to 0, thus, $\lim_{r_A \rightarrow 0} \gamma^*(\alpha) = 1$.

Supplemental Appendix

“Voter Resentment and the Strategic Dynamics of Enfranchisement”

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S1 Discrete posterior means

The ex ante probability of first-period enfranchisement does not coincide exactly with the continuous approximation $1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*$, because the posterior mean takes values on a discrete grid. The next result shows, however, that the discrepancy is uniformly small and vanishes as survey precision increases.

Remark 2. For every N ,

$$\left| \Pr[e_1 = 1 \mid N] - \left(1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N)\right) \right| \leq \frac{1}{N+2}.$$

Proof. Because the proof relies on results established below, we postpone it until Appendix S5. □

Substantively, the ex ante probability of enfranchisement closely inherits the comparative static pattern of the threshold established in Proposition 6: Greater precision encourages enfranchisement when Party A is weak and discourages it when A is strong. Figure S1 depicts ex ante first-period enfranchisement probability as a function of N for different values of γ .

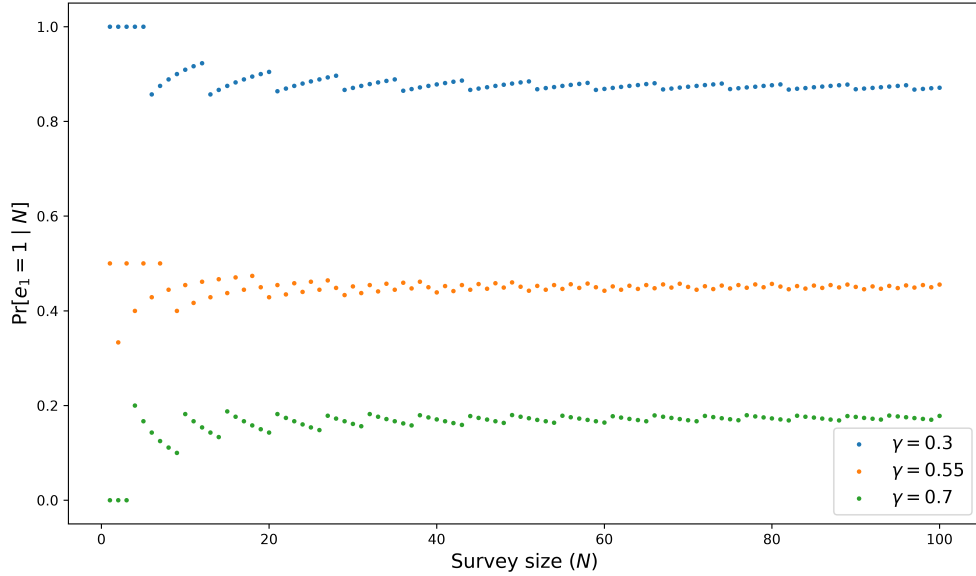


Figure S1: Ex ante first-period enfranchisement probability as a function of N .

S2 Proposition 5

Because parties' expected electoral payoffs are linear in θ_t , the posterior mean

$$\hat{\theta}_t = \mathbb{E}[\theta_t \mid \eta_t] = \frac{\eta_t + 1}{N + 2}$$

is a sufficient statistic for the enfranchisement decision. We proceed by backward induction.

In period 2, given resentment r_t^A , Party A's expected gain from enfranchisement is

$$\lambda \left((1 - \alpha r_t^A) \hat{\theta}_t - \gamma \right).$$

This expression is strictly increasing in $\hat{\theta}_t$. Thus, there exists a unique threshold $\hat{\theta}_2^*$ such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_t \geq \hat{\theta}_2^*$. Because the election is constant-sum, Party B's gain from enfranchisement is exactly the negative of Party A's, so Party B enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_t < \hat{\theta}_2^*$. In period 1, the continuation-value difference between enfranchisement and non-enfranchisement does not depend on η_1 , since θ_2 and η_2 are drawn independently of the first-period signal. Party A's payoff difference between enfranchisement and non-enfranchisement is therefore affine in $\hat{\theta}_1$, with slope $\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A) > 0$. It follows that there exists a unique threshold $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_1 \geq \hat{\theta}_1^*$.

S3 Proposition 6

i. Under the uniform prior, the probability that the period 2 survey returns exactly j respondents supporting Party A is

$$\Pr(\eta_2 = j) = \int_0^1 \binom{N}{j} \theta^j (1 - \theta)^{N-j} d\theta = \frac{1}{N + 1}, \quad j = 0, \dots, N.$$

Thus, each posterior mean $\hat{\theta}_2 = (j + 1)/(N + 2)$ occurs with probability $1/(N + 1)$, and $\mathbb{E}[\hat{\theta}_2] = 1/2$.

Suppose Party A does not enfranchise in period 1, so its resentment stock in period 2 is r_2^A . Let $k \in \{0, \dots, N + 1\}$ denote the number of posterior means satisfying $\hat{\theta}_2 < \gamma/(1 - \alpha r_2^A)$. These are precisely the realizations for which enfranchisement lowers Party A's election probability. Party B therefore enfranchises for these k realizations when it is incumbent, whereas Party A enfranchises for the remaining $N + 1 - k$ realizations when it is incumbent.

If potential voters have already been enfranchised, Party A's expected period 2 election probability is

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] = \gamma + \lambda \left(\frac{1 - \alpha r_A}{2} - \gamma \right).$$

If they remain disenfranchised, summing across the $N + 1$ equally likely posterior means gives

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] = \gamma + \lambda \left((1 - \alpha r_2^A) \left(\frac{\gamma}{2} + (1 - 2\gamma) \frac{k(k+1)}{2(N+1)(N+2)} \right) \right. \\ \left. - \gamma^2 - \gamma(1 - 2\gamma) \frac{k}{N+1} \right). \end{aligned}$$

Party A's period 1 payoff difference between enfranchisement and non-enfranchisement is therefore strictly increasing in $\hat{\theta}_1$, with slope $\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A) > 0$. Solving the indifference condition for $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ and differentiating with respect to α , holding k fixed, yields

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \hat{\theta}_1^*}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{1}{(1 - \alpha r_A)^2} \left(\gamma r_A + \delta r_A \gamma (1 - \gamma) - \frac{\delta}{2} (r_2^A - r_A) \gamma \right. \\ \left. + \delta(2\gamma - 1) \left(\frac{(r_2^A - r_A)k(k+1)}{2(N+1)(N+2)} + \frac{r_A \gamma k}{N+1} \right) \right). \end{aligned} \quad (10)$$

We first show that this derivative is negative for sufficiently weak parties. By Assumption 2, $(1 + \delta)r_A < \frac{\delta}{2}(r_2^A - r_A)$. For $\gamma \leq 1/2$, the first three terms inside the brackets in (10) can be written as

$$\gamma \left(r_A + \delta r_A (1 - \gamma) - \frac{\delta}{2} (r_2^A - r_A) \right).$$

Since $r_A + \delta r_A (1 - \gamma) \leq (1 + \delta)r_A$, Assumption 2 implies that this expression is strictly negative. The remaining term in (10) is weakly negative because $2\gamma - 1 \leq 0$. Thus, $\partial \hat{\theta}_1^* / \partial \alpha < 0$ for all $\gamma \in (0, 1/2]$.

At the other extreme, when $\gamma = 1$, all posterior means satisfy $\hat{\theta}_2 < 1/(1 - \alpha r_2^A)$, so $k = N + 1$. Substituting $\gamma = 1$ and $k = N + 1$ into (10), the expression inside the brackets becomes $(1 + \delta)r_A > 0$. Thus, $\partial \hat{\theta}_1^* / \partial \alpha > 0$ at $\gamma = 1$.

The sign must therefore change somewhere between $1/2$ and 1 . It remains to show that it changes only once.

As γ increases, k weakly increases. Whenever k increases from k to $k + 1$, the expression inside the brackets in (10) changes by

$$\delta(2\gamma - 1) \left(\frac{(r_2^A - r_A)(k+1)}{(N+1)(N+2)} + \frac{r_A \gamma}{N+1} \right).$$

For $\gamma > 1/2$, this expression is strictly positive. Thus, whenever a change in γ causes an additional survey realization to move into the set for which Party B enfranchises in period 2, $\partial\hat{\theta}_1^*/\partial\alpha$ moves upward. A change in the period 2 enfranchisement rule therefore cannot cause the derivative to switch from positive back to negative.

It remains to consider changes in the derivative within a region in which k is fixed. At any zero of the expression inside the brackets in (10), differentiating that expression with respect to γ and using the zero condition gives

$$\frac{\frac{\delta}{2}(r_2^A - r_A) - r_A - \delta r_A(1 - \gamma)}{2\gamma - 1} + \delta r_A \left((2\gamma - 1) \frac{k}{N + 1} - \gamma \right).$$

The first term is strictly greater than $\delta r_A \gamma$. Since $\gamma > 1/2$, this inequality is equivalent to

$$\frac{\delta}{2}(r_2^A - r_A) - r_A(1 + \delta) + 2\delta r_A \gamma(1 - \gamma) > 0.$$

By Assumption 2, the first two terms sum to a strictly positive number, while $2\delta r_A \gamma(1 - \gamma) \geq 0$. Thus, the inequality holds strictly.

The second term is weakly greater than $-\delta r_A \gamma$, since $(2\gamma - 1)k/(N + 1) \geq 0$. Their sum is therefore strictly positive. Thus, within every region in which k is fixed, any zero of $\partial\hat{\theta}_1^*/\partial\alpha$ is crossed from negative to positive.

We have shown that the derivative is negative for $\gamma \leq 1/2$, positive at $\gamma = 1$, moves upward whenever k changes, and can cross zero only from negative to positive within each fixed k region. Its sign therefore changes exactly once.

Denote the unique partisan-strength value at which this sign change occurs by $\gamma^*(\alpha, N)$. Then $\partial\hat{\theta}_1^*/\partial\alpha < 0$ for $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$ and $\partial\hat{\theta}_1^*/\partial\alpha > 0$ for $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$.

ii. Suppose Party A does not enfranchise in period 1, so that its resentment stock increases to r_2^A . In period 2, enfranchisement changes Party A's election probability by

$$\lambda \left((1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma \right).$$

Party A enfranchises when this expression is nonnegative, and Party B enfranchises when it is negative. Following first-period non-enfranchisement, Party A is the period 2 incumbent

with probability γ . Thus,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[V_2^A | E_2 = 0, N] &= \gamma + \lambda\gamma \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left\{ (1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0 \right\} \right] \\ &\quad + \lambda(1 - \gamma) \mathbb{E} \left[\min \left\{ (1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0 \right\} \right] \\ &= \gamma + \lambda\gamma \left(\frac{1 - \alpha r_2^A}{2} - \gamma \right) + \lambda(1 - 2\gamma) \mathbb{E} \left[\min \left\{ (1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0 \right\} \right].\end{aligned}\tag{11}$$

Greater survey precision weakly increases Party A's incentive to enfranchise when Party A is weak and weakly decreases its incentive to enfranchise when Party A is strong. In Equation 11 only the last expectation depends on N .

Suppose we increase the survey size from N to $N + 1$. Conditional on $\eta_2 = j$, the additional respondent supports Party A with probability

$$\frac{j + 1}{N + 2} = \hat{\theta}_{2,N}.$$

Thus,

$$\hat{\theta}_{2,N+1} = \begin{cases} \frac{j + 2}{N + 3}, & \text{w.p. } \frac{j + 1}{N + 2}, \\ \frac{j + 1}{N + 3}, & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \Rightarrow \mathbb{E}[\hat{\theta}_{2,N+1} | \eta_2 = j] = \frac{j + 1}{N + 2} = \hat{\theta}_{2,N}.$$

Given $\min(\cdot)$ is a concave function,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[\min\{(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N+1} - \gamma, 0\}] \\ &= \mathbb{E}_{\eta_2}[\mathbb{E}[\min\{(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N+1} - \gamma, 0\} | \eta_2 = j]] \\ &\leq \mathbb{E}_{\eta_2}[\min\{(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0\}] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[\min\{(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0\}],\end{aligned}\tag{12}$$

where the inequality follows from Jensen's inequality. Since $\mathbb{E} \left[\min \left\{ (1 - \alpha r_2^A) \hat{\theta}_{2,N} - \gamma, 0 \right\} \right]$ term enters the continuation value with coefficient $\lambda(1 - 2\gamma)$ (see Equation 11),

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A | E_2 = 0, N + 1] \begin{cases} \leq \mathbb{E}[V_2^A | E_2 = 0, N], & \text{if } \gamma < \frac{1}{2}, \\ = \mathbb{E}[V_2^A | E_2 = 0, N], & \text{if } \gamma = \frac{1}{2}, \\ \geq \mathbb{E}[V_2^A | E_2 = 0, N], & \text{if } \gamma > \frac{1}{2}. \end{cases}$$

If Party A, instead, enfranchises in period 1, the electorate remains enfranchised in period 2, so survey precision does not affect the continuation decision:

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] = \gamma + \lambda \left(\frac{1 - \alpha r_A}{2} - \gamma \right).$$

The unconstrained first-period threshold $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N)$ is such that

$$\lambda \left((1 - \alpha r_A) \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N) - \gamma \right) + \delta \left(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0, N] \right) = 0.$$

Thus,

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N) = \frac{\gamma - \frac{\delta}{\lambda} \left(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0, N] \right)}{1 - \alpha r_A}.$$

Because $1 - \alpha r_A > 0$,

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N + 1) \begin{cases} \leq \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma < \frac{1}{2}, \\ = \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma = \frac{1}{2}, \\ \geq \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma > \frac{1}{2}. \end{cases}$$

Finally, the equilibrium threshold is

$$\hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) = \max \left\{ 0, \min \left\{ 1, \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma, N) \right\} \right\}.$$

The truncation operator is weakly increasing, and, thus, it preserves the ordering. Therefore,¹⁵

$$\hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N + 1) \begin{cases} \leq \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma < \frac{1}{2}, \\ = \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma = \frac{1}{2}, \\ \geq \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N), & \text{if } \gamma > \frac{1}{2}. \end{cases}$$

S4 Remark 1

By Proposition 3, under Assumption 2,

$$\frac{\partial \theta_1^*}{\partial \alpha} < 0 \quad \text{for all } \gamma \leq \frac{1}{2}.$$

Thus, $\gamma^* \geq 1/2$.

¹⁵The inequalities may be weak because truncation can leave the equilibrium threshold fixed at 0 or 1 even when the unconstrained threshold changes.

S5 Remark 2

Under the uniform prior,

$$\Pr[\eta_1 = j \mid N] = \frac{1}{N+1}, \quad j = 0, \dots, N,$$

and the $N+1$ possible posterior means

$$\frac{1}{N+2}, \frac{2}{N+2}, \dots, \frac{N+1}{N+2}$$

are equally likely.

Let m denote the number of posterior means strictly below the equilibrium threshold $\hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N)$. Since Party A enfranchises if and only if $\hat{\theta}_1 \geq \hat{\theta}_1^*$,

$$\Pr(e_1 = 1) = 1 - \frac{m}{N+1}.$$

Thus,

$$\Pr[e_1 = 1 \mid N] - \left(1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N)\right) = \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) - \frac{m}{N+1}.$$

We next consider three cases: (i) when $1 \leq m \leq N$, (ii) when $m = 0$, and (iii) when $m = N+1$. Suppose first that $1 \leq m \leq N$. Having exactly m posterior means below the threshold implies

$$\frac{m}{N+2} < \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) \leq \frac{m+1}{N+2}.$$

$$\Leftrightarrow$$

$$-\frac{m}{(N+1)(N+2)} < \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) - \frac{m}{N+1} \leq \frac{N+1-m}{(N+1)(N+2)}.$$

Since both m and $N+1-m$ are at most N ,

$$\left| \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) - \frac{m}{N+1} \right| < \frac{1}{N+2}.$$

Suppose next $m = 0$, then

$$0 \leq \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) \leq \frac{1}{N+2}, \quad \Rightarrow \quad \left| \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) - \frac{m}{N+1} \right| \leq \frac{1}{N+2}.$$

If $m = N+1$, then

$$\frac{N+1}{N+2} < \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) \leq 1, \quad \Rightarrow \quad \left| \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N) - 1 \right| < \frac{1}{N+2}.$$

Combining cases we get

$$\left| \Pr(e_1 = 1) - \left(1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*(\alpha, \gamma, N)\right) \right| \leq \frac{1}{N+2}.$$

Since $1/(N+2) \rightarrow 0$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$, the difference between the exact probability of first-period enfranchisement and $1 - \hat{\theta}_1^*$ disappears.

S6 Proposition 7

i. Suppose first that Party A is the period 2 incumbent. If A enfranchises, its payoff is

$$(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) - c,$$

while if it does not enfranchise, its payoff is γ . Thus, A enfranchises if and only if

$$(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) - c \geq \gamma \quad \Leftrightarrow \quad \theta_2 \geq \frac{\gamma + c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}.$$

Since $\theta_2 \in [0, 1]$, the equilibrium threshold is

$$\theta_{2,A}^*(c) = \max \left\{ 0, \min \left\{ 1, \frac{\gamma + c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A} \right\} \right\}.$$

Suppose instead that Party B is the incumbent. If B enfranchises, its payoff is

$$1 - ((1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A)) - c,$$

while non-enfranchisement yields $1 - \gamma$. Thus, B enfranchises if and only if

$$1 - ((1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A)) - c > 1 - \gamma \quad \Leftrightarrow \quad \theta_2 < \frac{\gamma - c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}.$$

Again imposing $\theta_2 \in [0, 1]$ gives

$$\theta_{2,B}^*(c) = \max \left\{ 0, \min \left\{ 1, \frac{\gamma - c/\lambda}{1 - \alpha r_2^A} \right\} \right\}.$$

ii. For period 2, the result follows directly from the thresholds derived above. Whenever the thresholds are interior,

$$\frac{\partial \theta_{2,A}^*}{\partial c} = \frac{1}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_2^A)} > 0, \quad \frac{\partial \theta_{2,B}^*}{\partial c} = -\frac{1}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_2^A)} < 0.$$

Truncation to $[0, 1]$ makes these inequalities weak at the boundaries.

The unconstrained threshold for period 1 satisfies

$$\lambda((1 - \alpha r_A)\tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^* - \gamma) - c + \delta(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]) = 0.$$

Thus,

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^*}{\partial c} = \frac{1 + \delta \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]_c'}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A)}.$$

A higher cost reduction to Party A's period 2 payoff is bounded, $\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]_c' \geq -1$.

Since $\delta < 1$,

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^*}{\partial c} \geq \frac{1 - \delta}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A)} > 0.$$

Again, truncating to $[0, 1]$ we get the weak inequality for $\theta_{1,A}^*$.

S7 Proposition 8

Suppose first that both period 2 thresholds are interior. Following first-period obstruction, Party A's expected period 2 payoff is

$$\begin{aligned} & \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_1 = 0, e_1 = 0] \\ &= \gamma + \lambda \gamma \int_{\frac{\gamma+c/\lambda}{1-\alpha r_2^A}}^1 ((1 - \alpha r_2^A)\theta - \gamma - \frac{c}{\lambda}) d\theta + \lambda(1 - \gamma) \int_0^{\frac{\gamma-c/\lambda}{1-\alpha r_2^A}} ((1 - \alpha r_2^A)\theta - \gamma) d\theta. \end{aligned}$$

Differentiating with respect to c and γ we get

$$\frac{\partial^2}{\partial c \partial \gamma} \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_1 = 0, e_1 = 0] = -1 + \frac{2\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}.$$

The unconstrained first-period threshold $\tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^*(c)$ satisfies

$$\lambda((1 - \alpha r_A)\tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^*(c) - \gamma) - c + \delta(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_1 = 0, e_1 = 0]) = 0.$$

Since $\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1]$ is independent of c ,

$$\frac{\partial^2 \tilde{\theta}_{1,A}^*(c)}{\partial c \partial \gamma} = \frac{\delta}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A)} \left(-1 + \frac{2\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A} \right).$$

Thus,

$$\frac{\partial^2 \Pr[e_1 = 1 \mid c]}{\partial c \partial \gamma} = \frac{\delta(1 - \alpha r_2^A - 2\gamma)}{\lambda(1 - \alpha r_A)(1 - \alpha r_2^A)}.$$

This expression is positive for $\gamma < (1 - \alpha r_2^A)/2$, zero at $\gamma = (1 - \alpha r_2^A)/2$, and negative for $\gamma > (1 - \alpha r_2^A)/2$. Finally, if the unconstrained first-period threshold lies outside $[0, 1]$, truncated threshold is constant in c and the effect is zero. The proposition statement accounts for this with weak inequalities.

S8 Proposition 9

Since

$$\frac{\partial(c/\lambda)}{\partial \lambda} = -\frac{c}{\lambda^2},$$

$\theta_{t,A}^*$ is weakly decreasing in λ when $c > 0$, independent of λ when $c = 0$, and weakly increasing in λ when $c < 0$. The inequalities are reversed for $\theta_{2,B}^*$. Weak inequalities allow for thresholds truncated at zero or one.

S9 Proposition 10

Given that one party holds office following each election, the game is constant-sum

$$u_A + u_B = \sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \delta^t = \frac{1}{1 - \delta}.$$

Thus, it is sufficient to characterize Party A's expected discounted payoff. Party A maximizes this payoff, while Party B minimizes it. Consider a state (r_A, r_B) in which potential voters remain disenfranchised. Were they enfranchised at realization θ , Party A would win the current election with probability

$$(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda(\theta(1 - \alpha(r_A + r_B)) + \alpha r_B).$$

Enfranchisement is absorbing, so resentment remains fixed thereafter. Since future realizations of θ are independently drawn from $U[0, 1]$, Party A's expected probability of winning each subsequent election is

$$(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\left(\frac{1 - \alpha(r_A + r_B)}{2} + \alpha r_B\right).$$

Thus, Party A's expected discounted payoff following enfranchisement is

$$(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda(\theta(1 - \alpha(r_A + r_B)) + \alpha r_B) + \frac{\delta}{1 - \delta} \left((1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda \left(\frac{1 - \alpha(r_A + r_B)}{2} + \alpha r_B \right) \right).$$

Note that for every feasible resentment state satisfying $1 - \alpha(r_A + r_B) > 0$, this expression is strictly increasing in θ . Let $V_A(r_A, r_B)$ denote Party A's equilibrium continuation payoff when potential voters remain disenfranchised and Party A is the incumbent, and let $V_B(r_A, r_B)$ denote the corresponding payoff when Party B is the incumbent.

Suppose first that Party A is the incumbent. If it does not enfranchise, it wins the current election with probability γ , and resentment changes to $((1 - \beta)r_A + \beta, (1 - \beta)r_B)$. Party A's expected discounted payoff from non-enfranchisement is, thus,

$$\gamma + \delta(\gamma V_A((1 - \beta)r_A + \beta, (1 - \beta)r_B) + (1 - \gamma)V_B((1 - \beta)r_A + \beta, (1 - \beta)r_B)).$$

Crucially, this payoff is independent of the current realization of θ . The difference between Party A's payoff from enfranchisement and non-enfranchisement is continuous and strictly increasing in θ . Thus, there exists a unique threshold $\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B) \in [0, 1]$, such that Party A enfranchises if and only if $\theta \geq \theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$.

By a similar argument, when B is the incumbent, there exists a unique threshold $\theta_{B,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B) \in [0, 1]$, such that Party B enfranchises if and only if $\theta \leq \theta_{B,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B)$.

It remains to show that the continuation payoffs are well defined and unique. Consider two conjectured pairs of continuation payoffs, Current payoffs can differ across these conjectures only through the discounted continuation term. Because future payoffs are multiplied by $\delta < 1$, the largest difference between the implied current payoff is at most δ times the largest difference between the conjectured continuation payoffs. The mapping from continuation payoffs into current ones is, thus, a contraction. By the contraction mapping theorem, it has a unique fixed point, which, in turn, gives a unique stationary continuation payoffs V_A, V_B .

S10 Proposition 11

i. We first show that at every resentment state and for every realization of θ_t , one of the parties prefers to enfranchise. Recall that $V_A(r_A, r_B)$ and $V_B(r_A, r_B)$ denote Party A's continuation payoff when potential voters remain disenfranchise and either Party A or Party B, respectively, is incumbent. Both continuation payoffs are weakly decreasing in r_A and weakly increasing in r_B . Suppose the current resentment state is (r_A, r_B) . If A obstructs, the

next resentment state is $((1-\beta)r_A + \beta, (1-\beta)r_B)$. If B obstructs, it $((1-\beta)r_A, (1-\beta)r_B + \beta)$. Thus, from A's perspective, continued exclusion is weakly worse when A rather than B is the incumbent. Since the payoff from immediate enfranchisement does not depend on the incumbent, it follows that

$$\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B) \leq \theta_{B,MPE}^*(r_A, r_B).$$

Thus, for every (r_A, r_B) and every θ , at least one party would enfranchise if it were incumbent.

Conditional on continued exclusion, only core voters participate. A wins with probability γ and B with probability $1 - \gamma$. Given at least one would enfranchise for every state and every θ ,

$$\Pr[\tau = t | \tau \geq t] \geq \min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \Pr[\tau > t | \tau > t - 1] \leq 1 - \min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\}.$$

Thus,

$$\Pr[\tau > t] \leq (1 - \min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\})^{t-1} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \Pr[\tau < \infty] = 1.$$

ii. We next bound expected time to enfranchisement

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[\tau] &= 1 + \sum_{t=1}^{\infty} \Pr(\tau > t) \\ &\leq 1 + \sum_{t=1}^{\infty} (1 - \min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\})^{t-1} \\ &= 1 + \frac{1}{\min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\}}. \end{aligned}$$

S11 Proposition 12

Suppose first that $\delta = 0$. After k consecutive periods of exclusion,

$$r_{t+k}^A + r_{t+k}^B = 1 - (1 - \beta)^k (1 - r_A).$$

Given A is the incumbent in period t and each subsequent election elects B with probability $1 - \gamma$, expected resentment against B after k period of exclusion is

$$\mathbb{E}[r_{t+k}^B] = (1 - \gamma) (1 - (1 - \beta)^{k-1}).$$

When $\delta = 0$, Party A enfranchises once its support among potential voters exceeds its support among core voters. Therefore,

$$\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r^A, r^B; \alpha, \gamma) = \frac{\gamma - \alpha r^B}{1 - \alpha(r^A + r^B)}.$$

The assumption $\alpha_H < \min\{\gamma, 1 - \gamma\}$ guarantees that this cutoff is interior for both α_H and α_L at every resentment state.

Finally,

$$\begin{aligned} & \mathbb{E} \left(\theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_{t+k}^A, r_{t+k}^B; \alpha_H, \gamma) - \theta_{A,MPE}^*(r_{t+k}^A, r_{t+k}^B; \alpha_L, \gamma) \right) \\ &= \frac{(\alpha_H - \alpha_L) \left\{ \gamma (1 - (1 - \beta)^k (1 - r_A)) - (1 - \gamma) (1 - (1 - \beta)^{k-1}) \right\}}{(1 - \alpha_H (1 - (1 - \beta)^k (1 - r_A))) (1 - \alpha_L (1 - (1 - \beta)^k (1 - r_A)))}. \end{aligned}$$

Note that the denominator is positive and the expression in curly braces converges to $2 \cdot \gamma - 1$ as $k \rightarrow \infty$. Thus, there exists sufficiently large $K(\gamma)$ s.t. the signs stated in proposition holds for every $k > K(\gamma)$ at $\delta = 0$.

Next, given the continuation payoffs enter the incumbent's decision multiplied by the discount rate δ , as $\delta \rightarrow 0$ the MPE cutoff converges to the myopic cutoff. Given the difference above is bounded away from zero for all $k \geq K(\gamma)$, the same sign holds in the neighborhood of $\delta = 0$.